

Windows 365 Link

Microsoft's compact cloud PC to rival Apple Mac mini

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Taking a serious swing at miniaturising the good old desktop PC, Microsoft has announced the Windows 365 Link – a compact, fanless Windows PC aimed at connecting users directly to their Windows 365 Cloud PC in seconds. While it's currently aimed at business users in medium or large organisations – a more cloud-native version of a thin client – I can't help but wonder at the potential for this device to become Microsoft's response to Apple's Mac mini in the consumer market.

I mean why not? The Mac mini's been a favourite among those looking for a small yet powerful desktop computer without breaking the bank for a long time now.

So what's stopping Microsoft from extending the Windows 365 Link to everyday consumers like you and me?

The Windows 365 Link is an interesting piece of hardware. Yes, it has its pros and cons from an end user perspective (which I've highlighted

further in the article), but it should deserve a spot in retail stores alongside its intended business-focused rollout.

Windows 365 Link: What is it exactly?

At first glance, the Windows 365 Link is a small, unassuming device. Measuring just 4.72-in x 4.72-in x 1.18-in, it's a compact box that can easily sit on a desk or disap-



pear completely from view by being mounted behind a monitor. It's designed to boot up in seconds and provide instant access to a Windows 11 desktop streamed from the cloud – that's right, it doesn't have Windows 11 natively present on its

internal storage. The device comes equipped with an array of ports, including three USB-A 3.2 ports, one USB-C 3.2 port, HDMI and Display-Port outputs, an Ethernet jack, Wi-Fi 6E, and Bluetooth 5.3 connectivity.

As per Microsoft's announcement, the Windows 365 Link is intended exclusively for businesses and organisations – at least for now. Microsoft plans to launch it in a limited release in December 2024, and make it more generally available in April 2025, pricing starting at \$349 in select markets. So, where does that leave the average consumer?

Why the Windows 365 Link makes sense for consumers

Let's face it, at \$349 starting price, the Windows 365 Link is inexpensive and doesn't cost a fortune. It offers an accessible price point for consumers looking to experience Windows 11 without investing in a full-fledged PC. For students, freelancers, or anyone on a budget, this